Technical Writing and Scientific Typesetting

A Study of Digital Documentation Tools

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November 2026

Abstract

Technical writing plays an important role in communicating complex information clearly and effectively. Scientific typesetting tools such as LaTeX provide structured methods for preparing professional reports, academic documents, mathematical expressions, tables, and references.

This report examines the fundamental features of LaTeX, its document structure, mathematical typesetting capabilities, and its applications in technical documentation.

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1 Introduction

Technical writing is the process of presenting specialised information in a clear, organised, and accurate manner. It is widely used in engineering, science, research, and software development.

LaTeX is a document preparation system particularly suited to scientific and technical publications. Unlike conventional word processors, it separates document content from formatting instructions.

2 Objectives

The main objectives of this report are:

- To understand the purpose of LaTeX.
- To examine the basic structure of a LaTeX document.
- To demonstrate mathematical typesetting.
- To understand the creation of tables and lists.
- To explore the role of LaTeX in technical reports.

3 Structure of a LaTeX Document

A typical LaTeX document consists of two major parts:

1. **Preamble:** Contains the document class, packages, and formatting settings.
2. **Document body:** Contains the actual text, headings, equations, tables, and references.

The following example illustrates the basic structure:

```
\documentclass{article}
\begin{document}
Hello, World!
\end{document}
```

4 Mathematical Typesetting

One of the major advantages of LaTeX is its ability to represent complex mathematical expressions.

For example, the quadratic formula is:

$$x = \frac{-b \pm \sqrt{b^2 - 4ac}}{2a} \tag{1}$$

The summation notation can be represented as:

$$S = \sum_{i=1}^{n} x_i \tag{2}$$

The probability density function of a normal distribution is:

$$f(x) = \frac{1}{\sigma\sqrt{2\pi}} e^{-\frac{(x-\mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}} \tag{3}$$

5 Tables and Document Organisation

LaTeX allows information to be presented in structured tables.

Table 1: Common LaTeX Commands

Command	**Purpose**
`\section`	Creates a section
`\subsection`	Creates a subsection
`\textbf`	Applies bold formatting
`\includegraphics`	Inserts an image
`\tableofcontents`	Creates a contents page

6 Advantages of LaTeX

The major advantages of LaTeX include:

- Consistent and professional document formatting.
- High-quality mathematical typesetting.
- Automatic numbering of sections and equations.
- Support for tables, figures, and references.
- Suitability for large technical documents.

7 Conclusion

LaTeX is a powerful tool for preparing structured technical and scientific documents. Its mathematical typesetting capabilities, consistent formatting, and flexible document organisation make it useful for academic reports and research publications.

Understanding LaTeX provides a foundation for creating professional technical documentation.

References

[1] Leslie Lamport, *LaTeX: A Document Preparation System*, 2nd Edition, Addison-Wesley, 1994.

[2] Overleaf, *Learn LaTeX Documentation*. `https://www.overleaf.com/learn`